

## C8 Communication Preferences Discovery

*Formerly: Cross-Generational Communication. Rebuilt from scratch. The original relied on generational stereotypes that are empirically weak. This version focuses on individual preferences without generational labelling.*

| Pillar        | Communication     | Difficulty         | Level 1                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------|-------------------|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Time Required | 35-45 minutes     | Group Size         | 4-12                                                                                                                                          |
| Mode          | Team facilitation | Format             | In-person or remote                                                                                                                           |
| Prerequisites | None              | CLOVER ERA Trigger | Varying communication styles signals, cross-team friction, misaligned expectations about response times or channels, new team members joining |

### Why This Works

#### THE NEUROSCIENCE

Communication friction often has nothing to do with content and everything to do with format mismatch. When someone receives information through a channel or style that doesn't match their processing preference, their brain works harder to decode it. This increases cognitive load and reduces comprehension, even when the message itself is perfectly clear.

Preferences are neurologically real: some brains process verbal information more efficiently (auditory processing dominance), others process written information better (visual processing dominance). Some people need time to think before responding (reflective processing), others think by talking (active processing). None of these is better or worse. They are different neural architectures.

Making preferences explicit eliminates the guesswork that creates friction. Instead of assuming everyone processes information the same way, the team develops a shared reference for how to communicate effectively with each person.

### The Exercise

#### Phase 1: Individual Preference Mapping (10 minutes)

Each person fills out a Communication Preference Card with four questions:

4. How do I prefer to receive important information? (verbal, written, visual, meeting, 1:1, group)

5. How quickly do people need to expect a response from me? (immediate, same day, 24 hours, depends on channel)
6. What communication behaviour from others makes me most effective? (specific example)
7. What communication behaviour from others makes me least effective? (specific example)

#### FACILITATION NOTE

Questions 3 and 4 are the most valuable. "I work best when someone gives me the full picture upfront rather than drip-feeding information" is actionable in a way that "I prefer email" is not.

### Phase 2: Sharing Round (15 minutes)

Each person shares their card. The manager captures a team reference grid on the flipchart/Miro:

| Person | Preferred Channel | Response Time  | Most Effective | Least Effective |
|--------|-------------------|----------------|----------------|-----------------|
| [Name] | [Their answer]    | [Their answer] | [Their answer] | [Their answer]  |

This grid becomes a living team reference document. Post it in the team's shared space.

### Phase 3: Surprise and Adaptation (10 minutes)

#### WHAT TO SAY

"Looking at this grid, what surprises you? Where have you been communicating with someone in a way that doesn't match their preference? And where have you been frustrated by someone's communication without realising it's a preference difference, not a quality difference?"

The goal is to shift the frame from 'they communicate badly' to 'they communicate differently.' This reframe reduces interpersonal friction and builds mutual accommodation.

### Phase 4: One Adaptation Each (5 minutes)

Each person identifies one adaptation they'll make based on what they learned about a colleague's preferences. Public commitment creates accountability.

#### WHAT TO SAY

"One change each. Based on what you've heard, what's one thing you'll do differently in how you communicate with someone on this team? Be specific: who, what, when."

## Facilitation Notes

| Situation                                                                                             | Response                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Someone says "I shouldn't have to adapt to everyone else's preferences"                               | Reframe: "You're right that nobody can perfectly match everyone's preferences all the time. This isn't about contorting yourself. It's about being aware. If I know you process written information better than verbal, it takes me 30 seconds to follow up a conversation with a quick summary message. That's not a burden. That's professional competence." |
| The preference grid reveals that the team's default communication method doesn't work for most people | This is a valuable finding. "If our default doesn't match what most of us need, that's a system problem worth solving. What should our default be?" This connects directly back to C1 (Communication Audit).                                                                                                                                                   |

## Signs This Is Working

| Timeframe                   | What to Look For                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| During the session          | People discover something they didn't know about a colleague's preferences<br>The grid reveals mismatches that explain past friction<br>Adaptations are specific and doable                                                                              |
| Within 2-4 weeks            | Someone adapts their communication style for a colleague (sends a summary email after a verbal discussion, for example)<br>The preference grid is referenced when a new person joins the team<br>Communication friction between specific pairs decreases |
| CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks) | Communication scores improve<br>Varying communication styles signals decrease<br>Qualitative data references understanding or accommodation                                                                                                              |

## Cross-Pillar Connections

| Worksheet                              | Connection                                                                                                           | Direction         |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| <b>C1: Communication Audit</b>         | C1 maps channels; C8 maps how individuals prefer to use them. Together they create a complete communication picture. | Run C1 before C8  |
| <b>C13: Asynchronous Communication</b> | Preference discovery is particularly important for async teams where mismatches create the most friction.            | Run C8 before C13 |
| <b>V9:</b>                             | Understanding communication                                                                                          | Complementary     |

|                     |                                                                                  |  |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| Cultivating Empathy | preferences is an act of empathy. C8 provides the data; V9 provides the mindset. |  |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|